

SCIENTISTS THINK THAT SOME SPECIES OF FERNS HAVE BEEN ON EARTH FOR OVER 350 MILLION YEARS



CARNIVOROUS PLANTS

Some plants grow in soil that does not have many nutrients, so they get additional nutrients from animal prey, such as insects. Many attract their prey using colour and smell and then trap it. The plant's digestive juices break down the prey so it can be absorbed.



BUTTERWORT
This plant's leaves are covered with an insect-trapping sap. Small insects, such as gnats, get stuck, and their struggle releases the plant's digestive juices.

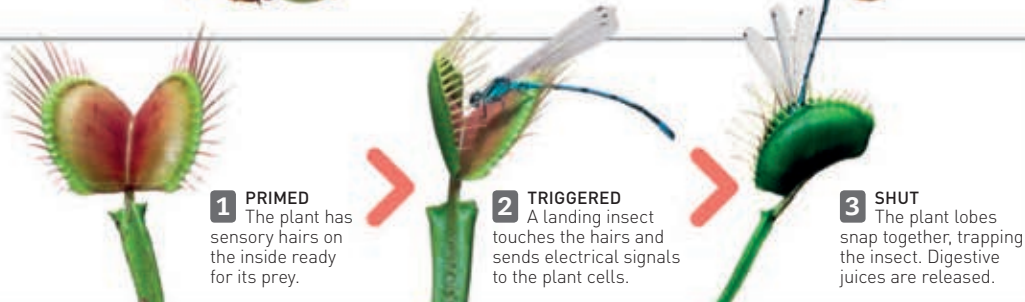
COBRA LILY
The traps on this plant look like snake heads. It contains cells that give off light and attractive smells to tempt hungry insects.



PITCHER PLANT
This tropical plant has cups (pitchers) that hang from trees and contain water to attract prey. Thirsty insects fall in – and become plant food.

CATCHING PREY

The Venus flytrap catches its insect prey very fast – it snaps shut in a tenth of a second. If an insect lands on the plant and touches sensory hairs, the plant snaps into action.



POISONOUS PLANTS

Some plants use poison as a protective device, so that people and animals do not eat them. These plants are among the deadliest to humans.

- OLEANDER**
The whole oleander plant is poisonous. Even smoke from burning oleander is highly toxic.
- WATER HEMLOCK**
The most deadly plant in North America, a tiny dose of this plant can be lethal if eaten. One species also occurs in Europe.
- ROSARY PEA**
These bright red seeds contain the most deadly plant poison known to humankind.
- DEADLY NIGHTSHADE**
All parts of this plant contain deadly toxins. The roots are the most dangerous part.
- CASTOR BEAN**
These contain ricin, one of the deadliest plant toxins. It is more toxic when inhaled than eaten.